

The Cast

PUBLIC · EVERYONE MAY READ

THE HOST OF THE EVENING (NOT PLAYED)

Bartholomew “Barty” Thistle, retired jam magnate. Barty made a fortune from Thistle’s Preserves, bought Thistledown House near the village of Fernley, and loves a garden, a good supper and a glass of elderflower cordial in the study before every meal. Barty is generous, stubborn and a little fussy about money.



Core characters

ALWAYS IN PLAY

10 · CORE

Rowan Thistle
HEIR TO THISTLEDOWN
HOUSE

Barty’s late sister’s child and the heir to Thistledown House, as everyone in Fernley knows. Rowan runs a small bookshop in town called Thistle & Page and visits the house most weekends.

What to wear: A tweed jacket or a soft cardigan, a silk scarf, and the slightly rumpled air of someone who will one day inherit a very large house and a very small budget for heating it.

11 · CORE

Ellis Fairweather
FAMILY DOCTOR

Fernley’s village doctor and Barty’s physician for twenty years. Ellis calls at Thistledown House every Saturday at five to check Barty’s weak heart, and has long dreamed of a new wing for Fernley Cottage Hospital.

What to wear: A dark waistcoat or a tidy cardigan, a pocket watch on a chain, spectacles if you have them, and a battered leather doctor’s bag (any handbag will do).

12 · CORE

Morgan Pike
STEWARD OF THISTLEDOWN
HOUSE

The steward who has run Thistledown House for twenty-five years. Morgan knows every creaking stair, every routine and every one of Barty’s habits, including the glass of elderflower cordial in the study before supper.

What to wear: A crisp dark jacket or waistcoat, a white shirt, a ring of keys at the belt and a dusting cloth peeping from one pocket.

13 · CORE

Sage Whitlock
FAMILY SOLICITOR

Barty’s solicitor, of Whitlock & Crane in Fernley, and the trustee of the Thistle Trust, the fund Barty set up for the cottage hospital and the village almshouses. Sage came down this afternoon to go over the Trust’s quarterly statement and is staying the night in the Blue Room.

What to wear: A pinstriped suit or a smart dark dress, spectacles on a chain, and a leather document case tucked under one arm.

The Cast, continued

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Optional characters

JOIN IN ORDER AT 5, 6, 7 AND 8 PLAYERS

14 · OPTIONAL · JOINS AT 5

Harper Vale

FOOD CRITIC

The feared “Table Talk” columnist of the London Evening Courier. Harper once wrote a famously unkind review of Thistle’s Harvest Jam and has been invited to the supper anyway.

What to wear: A velvet jacket, a bold bow tie or brooch, and a little notebook and pencil for taking notes on every course.

15 · OPTIONAL · JOINS AT 6

Quinn Ashby

HEAD GARDENER

Head gardener at Thistledown House for twelve years. Quinn grows Barty’s prize marrows and makes the house elderflower cordial every June from the hedgerows.

What to wear: A flat cap or a headscarf, rolled sleeves, a canvas apron or waistcoat, and a sprig of thistle or wheat in a buttonhole.

16 · OPTIONAL · JOINS AT 7

Avery Lark

NEWSPAPER REPORTER

A reporter for the Fernley Gazette, invited to write up the Harvest Supper for the society page. Avery came down on the late train.

What to wear: A trench coat or a belted cardigan, a hat with a card tucked in the band reading “PRESS,” and a pencil behind one ear.

17 · OPTIONAL · JOINS AT 8

Jules Marchetti

VISITING CHEF

A celebrated chef staying at Thistledown House for the autumn to write a cookbook with Barty. Jules created the Harvest Supper menu and has strong opinions about all of it.

What to wear: A white chef’s jacket or an apron over smart clothes, a neckerchief, and a wooden spoon to wave for emphasis.

PLAYING WITH FEWER THAN EIGHT?

Optional characters who aren’t cast simply weren’t at Thistledown tonight. The mystery works in full with the four core characters.